Sulphur (cepa) Import: CIS → South Korea

Laws, routes, full cost calculation for 1 t, 10 t, 100 t and 1,000 t · prepared 30 October 2026

Bottom line. Today only **Uzbekistan** and **Turkmenistan** can legally export sulphur among CIS producers; Kazakhstan and Russia have export bans, and Kyrgyzstan produces none. With 2026 prices and freight, **1 t and 10 t lots lose money** because fixed costs dominate; **100 t is near break-even**; trading starts to work at **~500–1,000 t in wagon lots** with a purchase price of **≤ $550–570/t**. Until a real quote meets that, act as a **commission broker** for your Korean clients.

1. Which countries allow export (October 2026)

Country	Status	Verdict
Uzbekistan	Mubarek GPP, 150 kt/yr granulated unit. No 2026 export ban found (not yet officially confirmed).	**YES**, verify
Turkmenistan	Turkmengaz sells via State Commodity Exchange (SCRMET); Oct 2026 buyers from Türkiye, UAE, Singapore.	**YES**
Kazakhstan	Full export ban from 27 Jun 2026 (Energy Ministry), no end date; only Russia-bound exempt.	**NO**, blocked
Russia	Export ban to 31 Dec 2026 (Decree 785); EAEU exempt. Sanctions/payment risk after.	**NO**, blocked
Kyrgyzstan	No production. Stock is Kazakh-origin → re-export while KZ ban is in force = circumvention risk. Costliest route.	**NO**, not recommended
Belarus	Naftan (US) and Mozyr (EU, 23 Jul 2026) refineries sanctioned.	**NO**, avoid
Azerbaijan	Small refinery output, no export data, very long route.	**NO**, not practical

2. South Korea import rules for sulphur (HS 2503.00)

• **Duty:** ~0–2% on CIF (basic 2%, WTO 0%); no FTA with KZ, TM, UZ, KG, RU. Confirm on UNI-PASS. 2% used in the model.
• **VAT:** 10% on CIF + duty, recoverable once VAT-registered.
• **Hazardous Materials Safety Act:** sulphur is Class 2 flammable solid, designated quantity 100 kg. Larger storage needs a licensed facility: deliver port → client directly.
• **K-REACH:** import ≥ 1 t/yr requires registration or coverage by the supplier's Only Representative; chemical confirmation for each import (KCMA). Sulphur's exact status still to be confirmed.
• **Market:** Korea is a net sulphur exporter (refinery by-product), so clients can buy locally: you must beat their current price.

3. What you can do as a Kazakhstan citizen resident in Korea

• Visas allowing a business: **F-2, F-4, F-5, F-6, D-8, D-9**. D-2, D-10, E-9, H-2 generally cannot (act only as an introducer or change status). Confirm on HiKorea.
• Setup: business registration (Hometax) → customs code (UNI-PASS) → trade business number (KITA, free).
• Advantage: Russian language, access to Central Asian exchanges, ready for Kazakh supply when the ban ends.

4. Step-by-step route

1. Get written client demand: grade (lump/granular), purity, monthly volume, current price, delivery point; ideally an LOI.
2. Register in Korea: business registration, customs code, KITA trade number.
3. Arrange K-REACH coverage (Only Representative / letter of access) and chemical confirmation.
4. Request a written quote and export confirmation from Uzbekneftegaz / Uzbek exchange (or register at SCRMET via a broker).

5. Book rail: origin → Kazakhstan transit → Altynkol/Khorgos → China → Lianyungang; sea feeder to Busan.
6. Payment back-to-back: client LC or deposit → your payment to supplier, so you never fund cargo yourself.
7. Clear Korean customs in Busan; hazmat-licensed truck straight to the client.

5. Routes

Route	Path	Days	Per 20ft to Busan
Uzbekistan	Mubarek → rail via KZ → Altynkol → Lianyungang → ship to Busan	~30	~$3,520
Turkmenistan	Turkmen rail → UZ/KZ transit → Altynkol → Lianyungang → Busan	~32	~$3,820
Kyrgyzstan	Truck Bishkek → Torugart → Kashgar → China rail → Lianyungang → Busan	~38	~$5,220
Caspian (TM)	Turkmenbashi → Baku → Poti/Batumi → Suez → Busan	~55	~$230/t (uneconomic)
1 t lots	Groupage (shared freight), any of the above	+8	$450–520/t
Avoid	Iran / Bandar Abbas (sanctions, Hormuz crisis)	-	-

A 20ft container carries ~25 t of bagged sulphur. China→Busan sea leg: $378–455 per 20ft (Oct 2026).

6. Full calculation per lot size: Uzbekistan route (cost per tonne, USD)

Cost item	1 t	10 t	100 t
Sulphur purchase price	900	800	680
Export docs, certificate of origin, broker, bagging	500	80	30
Freight to Busan	450	352	141
Cargo insurance	50	6	3
Korean import duty (2% of CIF)	38	25	17
Busan port, broker, chemical check, hazmat truck	700	105	34
Financing (60 days) + FX buffer 1%	66	32	21
Total cost per tonne delivered	**2,704**	**1,399**	**925**
Assumed sale price per tonne (ask clients)	1,100	1,000	900
Profit / loss on the lot	**−$1,604**	**−$3,994**	**−$2,511**
Margin	-145.8%	-39.9%	-2.8%

Purchase price assumed: 1–10 t from a distributor ($900 / $800, bagged); 100 t from producer $680 + $15/t bagging. Financing 8%/yr for 30 days transit + 30 days payment terms.

7. All routes compared: total cost per tonne delivered to client

Route	1 t	10 t	100 t	Max buy price for 10% margin (100 t)
Uzbekistan	$2,704	$1,399	$925	$570/t
Turkmenistan	$2,736	$1,431	$938	$558/t
Kyrgyzstan	$2,834	$1,632	$1,103	$501/t

8. 1,000 t trial (wagon/container lots, buy $650/t, sell $900/t)

Route	Days	Cost per t	Profit	Margin
C. Kazakhstan (Tengiz) -> Altynkol -> Lianyungang -> Busan [BLOCKED until KZ ban lifts]	28	$883	$16,571	1.8%

Route	Days	Cost per t	Profit	Margin
A. Turkmenistan -> rail via KZ/Khorgos -> Lianyungang -> Busan (containers)	30	$900	$487	0.1%
B. Turkmenistan -> Caspian -> Poti -> sea via Suez -> Busan	55	$991	−$90,621	-10.1%

Sensitivity (Turkmenistan route, 1,000 t): buy $550 → +$105k (11.7%); buy $650 → break-even; buy $750 → −$104k.

9. Market prices (benchmarks)

• Middle East FOB $740–790/t; CFR China granular $800–850/t (22 Oct 2026).
• October 2026 Middle East contracts $820–890/t FOB, $45–70 below September.
• Turkey Tupras domestic tender Sept 2026: $866–875/t FCA.
• Early 2026 was ~$500–525/t; analysts expect prices to fall in 2027: **never hold unsold stock**.

10. Recommendation & next steps

• **Now:** work as a commission broker (1–3%) between Korean clients and large traders: no capital, no hazmat or freight risk.
• **Trade yourself** only with ≥ 100 t (better 500–1,000 t) and a written buy price ≤ ~$570/t, or a client price ≥ ~$1,030/t for 100 t.
• **Send the Trade Advisor:** your visa type; client grade, volume and current price; supplier and forwarder quotes. The model is re-run in a minute.
• **2027:** watch for the end of the Kazakh ban: Tengiz sulphur via China is the cheapest lane.

Sources (checked 30 Oct 2026)

• Kazakhstan ban: petrocouncil.kz; Sulphur Magazine Sept 2026 (bcinsight.crugroup.com)
• Russia ban to end-2026: alta.ru/external_news/129074; news.metal.com
• Turkmen exchange sales: trend.az/casia/turkmenistan/4234836.html; business.com.tm
• Uzbekistan: yuz.uz (Uzbekneftegaz 2022 sales); caspianpost.com (Mubarek granulation)
• Kyrgyzstan imports: tradingeconomics.com; akipress.com/news:926519
• Belarus sanctions: EU 21st package, 23 Jul 2026 (lovguiden.dk / EUR-Lex)
• Korea tariff 2503: treayo.com/en/hs/korea/25030000 (confirm on unipass.customs.go.kr)
• Korea hazmat (sulphur 100 kg): kfsi.or.kr
• Korea trade in sulphur: oec.world
• Prices: chemportal.com.tr; petrolodex.com; fertilizerdaily.com
• China→Busan freight: sino-shipping.com
• Visas: kowork.kr (confirm on hikorea.go.kr)

Disclaimer: purchase prices, rail freight and Korean sale prices are estimates, not quotes. Laws and prices change; confirm with a licensed Korean customs broker and freight forwarder before committing money.